sent letters throughout England," says Roger of Wendover, "to those earls, barons, and knights, who appeared to be still faithful to the king . . . and advised them . . . to stand firm and fight against the king for their rights and for peace. . . . [T]he greatest part of these, on receiving the message of the barons, set out to London and joined them, abandoning the king entirely."[10]

With the party of the barons growing daily, John decided to negotiate. He was short on money, suffering from a severe attack of gout, and had no intention of keeping to any promise made under duress in any case. He sent word to the rebel barons by way of William Marshal, now close to seventy and in his forty-fifth year of service to the English throne, that he would meet them at a time and place of their choosing.

They chose a field lying between Staines and Windsor: Runnymede, a water meadow on the Thames. On June 15, the "whole nobility of England . . . in numbers not to be computed" assembled on one side of the field; John, carried on a litter because of the severity of his gout, and his few remaining supporters on the other. "At length," Roger of Wendover writes, "king John, seeing that he was inferior in strength to the barons, without raising any difficulty, granted the underwritten laws and liberties, and confirmed them by his charter."[11]

The Magna Carta, the Great Charter confirmed by John at Runnymede, bears the date June 15, 1215; but in fact John and the barons negotiated with each other for most of the week, amending and adding to the articles before the charter was finally sworn out. In its final form, the Magna Carta provided the barons with multiple layers of protection against the king's whimsy; it protected their goods, their lands, and their inheritances against John's arbitrary decrees; it rested the final decision over fines and scutages in the "common counsel of our realm," a gathering of churchmen, earls, and barons (known, since William the Conqueror, as the Curia Regis, and now invested with additional powers). "No one," read Article 39,

> shall be taken or imprisoned or dispossessed or outlawed or exiled or in any way ruined, nor will we go or send against him, except by the lawful judgement of his peers or by the law of the land.[12]

To make sure that the charter was observed, the Magna Carta also appointed a committee of twenty-five barons who had the power to confiscate royal castles, lands, and possessions, should John refuse to abide by its terms.*

This was a massive shift in authority, but John signed it; in large part, because he'd already laid plans in place to get out of it. Before coming to